



Figure 1: Slightly customised KDE desktop

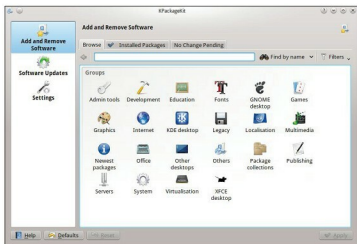


Figure 2: KPackageKit shows software groups

in Dolphin is the way it handles copying a file into a folder where a file of the same name already exists. It pops up a useful window, showing previews of both files, providing options for overwriting or renaming the file (check out Figure 6).

Also of note is the mechanism for dealing with the status of an ongoing job (such as file copy) and the notification of completed jobs. All such notifications are grouped into a box that pops up above the notification icon area. You can selectively expand, collapse or dismiss notifications (see Figure 7). The Firefox download completion notification also has the Plasma notification look (it may even be integrated—its appearance makes it difficult to tell).

The network manager also shows details (including traffic) of connected network devices, as you can see in Figure 8.

As far as the larger applications are concerned, there are three of note here, none of which is included in the KDE spin live CD image—they need to be installed separately. The first is, of course, *rekonq*, the new KDE Web browser (see Figure 9). It's fast, and has a few nice features such as pages for favourites, bookmarks, history, etc, but it's still not mature enough to 'Konquer' Firefox. It generally works well, but has problems with a few sites like Gmail, in which parts of the page appear above the page area (but Gmail still works correctly, unlike in Konqueror); and the WordPress post editing system, which did not work for me in WYSIWYG mode.

Bangarang (see Figure 10) is a new KDE multimedia

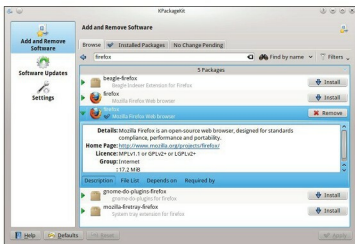


Figure 3: KPackageKit shows application icons



Figure 4: Local holidays in the calendar

player. As an application, this one is much more usable than *rekonq*. It plays everything except video CDs (they are cheaper, and free of illogical encryption), I had to bring back good old SMPPlayer, but just for that. For everything else, Bangarang rocks! The Fedora system uses Xine as the Phonon backend by default, which, complemented by RPM

Fusion, is something I have always liked better than GStreamer with its good, bad and ugly (and many other) plug-ins.

However, where the system really shines is when Bangarang plays video while 3D effects are enabled on the desktop. If taskbar thumbnails are enabled, hovering over the Bangarang taskbar entry displays the actual moving video (Figure 11). This may be the case with other multimedia players too, but I've not checked that out.

The last of the three is OpenOffice. Fedora has decided to include the pre-release version 3.3.0, but it works well enough. The new white splash screen is nice. The venerable OpenOffice, whose future had become doubtful with Oracle, has recently found a haven in The Document Foundation, which is a collaborative organisation, with various supporting companies, working to maintain a fork of OpenOffice called LibreOffice.

GNOME

The changes in GNOME are not so radical as the ones in KDE. GNOME in Fedora 14 is at version 2.32, and the default desktop is still pretty much the same as before. The GNOME 2.32 release notes specify a few new features included in the latest version. Chief among these are several updates to Empathy, the instant messaging client, and Evince,